

Aristotle outlines his **theory of justice** based on the idea that laws should conform to **natural law**, which is **universal and unchanging**.



c. 340 BCE

The **customary laws of India** are described in two Sanskrit works, the **Arthashastra** and the **Manusmriti**.



2ND CENTURY BCE

Jurist Domitius Ulpianus (Ulpian) writes more than 200 influential **commentaries and treatises on Roman law**.



212–222 CE

348 BCE



In *Laws*, **Plato** proposes an initial **dictatorship** guided by a **wise legislator** for city-states before **elected officials** can take charge.

286 BCE



The Roman tribune **Aquilius** proposes the **Lex Aquilia** to provide financial **compensation** for **wrongful damage to property**.

70 CE



After the **Second Temple of Jerusalem** is **destroyed**, Jewish people respond with closer observation of the **Torah's laws**.

c. 313 CE



The **Edict of Milan** decriminalizes **Christian worship** in the Roman Empire, paving the way for the **first systematic collections of canon law**.

punishment for offenses. In the 2nd century BCE, after more than 250 years of conflict during the Warring States period, a Legalist dynasty finally established order, although its severity was soon discredited. Confucianism became the predominant ideology, albeit reinforced with a strict code of law.

From the 5th century BCE, the city-state of Athens had instituted a form of direct democracy, where all adult citizens could participate in government. But in his *Republic* and *Laws*, the Greek philosopher Plato argued for government by the few—a class of “philosopher-kings” in an ideal state, or an initial dictator guided by a wise legislator. He maintained that only those trained in philosophy were capable of understanding the concepts of government and justice. His pupil

Aristotle advocated a form of constitutional government by the people and believed that legislation must be in harmony with natural law.

India, by contrast, favored a strictly hierarchical society divided into castes, as advocated in the *Arthashastra* and *Manusmriti* of the 2nd century BCE.

Rome and the Church

In about 509 BCE, when the Romans overthrew their tyrannical king, Lucius Tarquinius Superbus, they established the Roman Republic—a constitutional government ruled by two elected consuls. In c. 450 BCE, the new Republic published its first written law code—the Twelve Tables, inscribed on 12 bronze tablets—which set out the rights and duties of Roman citizens. As

the Roman Empire expanded, the laws were revised by jurists such as Ulpian but formed the basis of Roman law for a thousand years.

In c. 313 CE, Emperor Constantine, a convert to Christianity, issued the Edict of Milan, which proclaimed religious tolerance throughout the Roman Empire, ending the persecution of Christians. In 380 CE, Christianity became the Empire’s official religion, and Christian theologians could begin to formulate law based on Christian teachings.

The early canons, derived from disputes about what people should believe, were the foundation of Roman Catholic canon law, the body of law that regulates the organization of the Church and codifies Christian beliefs. Canon law influenced the development of civil law in medieval Europe. ■